



» SPOTLIGHT CHALLENGES OF PAST WINNERS

Proven contenders: No side has defended the women's ODI World Cup since Australia's hat-trick between 1978 and 1988, yet few would be startled if this Aussie team broke the long drought. GETTY IMAGES

GLORY ONCE WON, GLORY STILL TO DEFEND

To win once is history; to win again is reinvention. At the 2025 Women's ODI World Cup, past champions confront the **harder task** of staying ahead.

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World Cups are as much about legacy as they are about the moment. Winning once cements an irrefutable status, but winning again often demands reinvention. That reality now faces Australia, England and New Zealand — the only teams to have lifted the Women's ODI crown.

As the 2025 edition begins in India, each arrives at a crossroads: Australia adjusting to life without Meg Lanning, England reshaping under captain Nat Sciver-Brunt and

head coach Charlotte Edwards, and New Zealand balancing ageing stalwarts with untested promise.

The question now is: can these champions adapt and stay ahead in a rapidly changing landscape?

Continuity meets firepower

For Australia, transition has been more evolution than upheaval. Meg Lanning's shock retirement closed an era, but with 10 of the 2022 squad retained, stability underpins the side while younger players step up.

Alyssa Healy has assumed the

captaincy with assurance, combining calm leadership and explosive batting. Beth Mooney, Ashleigh Gardner and Megan Schutt add balance, while Alana King and Annabel Sutherland inject energy. Even without Lanning and depth, a strong Women's Big Bash League (WBBL) pipeline and structured development keep Australia ahead of the curve.

The challenge lies in sustaining hunger. Blending proven match-winners with fresh faces, the seven-time champion pursues an